

WASHINGTON STATE

'Not impressed with the company': Flock cameras spark debate over privacy, public safety in Chelan County

By Kalie Worthen, The Wenatchee World, Wash. *The Tribune Content Agency*

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Flock Safety, the \$8.4 billion surveillance camera company, and its automatic license plate readers, or ALPRs, grew out of a series of unsolved home break-ins. Since its inception in 2017, Flock Safety has become a tool used by almost 5,000 law enforcement agencies nationwide, including four local law enforcement agencies in Chelan and Douglas counties, and a source of controversy.

Four, "maybe five," of the 12 Flock cameras placed within Chelan County municipalities and rural areas since early 2025 have been vandalized, according to Chelan County Sheriff Mike Morrison at the Cashmere City Council meeting Sept. 14.

"I hear people's concern. I think they're certainly concerned about the ramifications of how intrusive this can be. I think we should be cautious and of course alert. But to just throw it out, would definitely be detrimental," Morrison said. "This is not mounted anywhere where you have a right to privacy anyways."

Morrison acknowledged that Flock Safety is flawed and said he is "not happy with the company," but maintained it is a "gamechanger" for law enforcement. Automatic license plate readers are used by law enforcement to assist with investigations involving AMBER and Silver alerts, stolen vehicles and active search warrants.

"I did speak with half a dozen people, and the opinion was if you're not doing anything wrong, what're you worried about?" Cashmere City Councilmember Jayne Stephenson said. "They felt they were beneficial."

Morrison credited one of the 12 cameras in the county, a Leavenworth-based ALPR, for the arrest of an Oregon homicide suspect near Lake Wenatchee.

"Our deputies didn't pick up on that, we weren't in that area, we didn't see it."

Morrison referenced a Kittitas County Flock camera that captured a suspect in a Wenatchee drive-by shooting as an example of ALPR success. He also credited ALPR cameras with helping track down Zachary Soltis, a 28-year-old Texas man who used his Toyota Tundra to vandalize Leavenworth's Front Street Park, also known as Gazebo Park, in 2025.

"As we're talking to the suspect and he's telling us, 'Yeah, I'm turning around to turn myself in.' (We're like) That's weird, because we're watching you drive through Moses Lake right now. Doesn't look like you're turning around," Morrison said. "Now I'm watching you drive into Idaho and if you think you're going to drive down to Texas... we are going to return you back. I have you on video surveillance."

The Chelan County Sheriff's Office is treating its Flock cameras, obtained through a Washington Auto Theft Prevention grant, as a two-year "pilot program," Morrison said at Sept. 14's Cashmere City Council meeting.

"I don't like mass surveillance and I believe Flock cameras are mass surveillance. Any time you're recording license plate numbers and interconnecting that over a large area over a long time, collecting all that data, that becomes surveillance in my opinion," Chris Carlson, a Cashmere City Council member, said.

Diane Potter, a Cashmere resident, emailed Morrison in July expressing support for law enforcement and appreciation while also requesting the removal of Flock cameras. Potter also requested that a public hearing be required before surveillance technology is installed. Her email prompted the Flock Safety discussion at the council meeting.

Carlson said he has heard from constituents who are uneasy about Flock cameras and that no one he has spoken with has expressed support for them.

Potter wrote, "Law-abiding residents should not have their daily movements recorded simply because they drive on public roads."

When a vehicle passes a Flock camera, its "fingerprint" is recorded in the agency's network. The camera captures the license plate number and identifying vehicle details, from the color of the vehicle to a bike rack or a Baby on Board decal.

"Chelan County has several vacation rentals and those individuals are not (always) there so the fact that we have cameras in those areas, watching who comes and goes out of certain spots certainly has helped us with burglaries when they (homeowners) come through later on 'Hey we had our house broken in the last couple of weeks,'" Morrison said. "They'll have their ring cameras and say all we got was this side angle of the car but it looked like it had a dent in the front corner. Let's type it in and see if we can find anything in that area with a dent in the front."

Artificial intelligence uses the collected information to create the "fingerprint" and adds the location and time of the vehicle. The data is then logged into a database accessible by approved agencies. Vehicle data can be retrieved to assist with investigations, such as when a vehicle is stolen or traced to an AMBER Alert.

"We could have found the Decker girls much quicker because we would have seen him turn onto Icicle Road. Instead, the only camera that was up and running was the city of Wenatchee that did detect (Travis Decker) leaving the city. Had ours been up and running... maybe those girls would still be alive." Morrison also mentioned the Chelan Hills Fire investigation would've had a more rapid turnaround with ALPR cameras. "We would have had the suspect in custody a month ago, two months ago. It would've sped up our investigation."

The Chelan County Sheriff's Office covers about 2,900 square miles and has a population of about 80,000, with a large concentration of tourism and outdoor recreation within its jurisdiction. The office has 59 commissioned deputies, who are spread thin, Morrison said, citing the combined roughly 8 million visitors Leavenworth and Chelan draw, wildfire assistance assignments and search-and-rescue operations.

In comparison, the sheriff's office had 68 commissioned deputies serving a population of about 70,000 in 2008.

"It is more effective to utilize AI and other technology to expand our capabilities and our ability to get the job done at a more cost effective rate," Morrison said. Homeowners associations, commonly known as HOAs, and small businesses also use the technology, Morrison added. "You can't have a security guard on duty 24/7 awake. Technology doesn't take days off, doesn't take rest."

Cashmere City Council member Jeff Johnson noted that cost savings could be an incentive from the perspective of taxpayer funds if Flock cameras are an alternative to a deputy, which would be "very expensive."

The Flock camera discussion came after the council approved a roughly \$4 rate increase for Waste Management and a new jail rate for the Chelan County Regional Jail.

"Anything that has the prospect of potentially lowering costs and creating a safer community is something that ought to be explored," Johnson said.

Kim Mires, a Wenatchee-based delivery driver, said she climbs into her delivery truck every morning and willingly allows herself to be tracked throughout her route so customers can follow their packages. She is also recorded by an in-cab camera installed by her employer for safety. She drops packages in front of Ring cameras and has no qualms about that. But the Flock Safety cameras mounted throughout the two-county Chelan-Douglas area are different for Mires, who said she feels as if she is being "tracked" even when she is off the clock.

"I honestly just feel like there is a lack of privacy in the Valley," Mires said. "I fear for my Hispanic community being targeted."

Carlson questioned where the collected data goes and who controls it. Flock Safety drew statewide attention to the Wenatchee and East Wenatchee police departments in October 2025 after a University of Washington article revealed

that the two departments unknowingly shared network access with the federal government, including U.S. Border Patrol, through a default setting.

"I think Flock has missed the mark on several fronts. I'm not impressed with the company," Morrison said. "I think the technology is outstanding, excellent, but I think they've done damage to our relationship with citizens in the state, and specifically folks in Chelan County."

East Wenatchee City Council tabled a Flock camera "master agreement" Sept. 15 after several local residents raised concerns about the technology.

Gov. Bob Ferguson signed Senate Bill 6002, known as the "Driver Privacy Act," into law in March. The law shortens the length of time ALPR data can be stored from 30 days to 21 days, unless it is being used in an active case.

"As new technology comes out, it's going to have to be curtailed. Just like we're watching with AI right now. Just like we're watching with autonomous vehicles," Morrison said. "There was a benefit and positivity to the technology when it came out but there's going to be some learning curves."

Senate Bill 6002 also prevents ALPR cameras from being mounted in specific public spaces. Under the law, Washington state does not allow ALPR programs near hospitals, places of worship, immigration facilities, courts or food banks.

"Washington state is probably one of the most difficult places to do law enforcement anywhere in the U.S. Even they're (the government) saying this is lawful," Morrison said. "The law is going to catch up with ALPR. I think we've done pretty well staying ahead of it. We've been compliant with everything the state's put forward even before they put it out as a requirement."

Morrison confirmed that the Chelan County Sheriff's Office does not share its data with the federal government and that commissioned staff who use the data must have a case number. The software also logs a user's activity to help

identify potential misuse, and the undersheriff is tasked with monitoring activity.

"We try to be responsible. We don't want to invade privacy. None of these cameras are mounted in a place where you're deemed to have privacy anyway," Morrison said. "It's not like it's giving secrets of someone's internet search history that would be private. You are driving your car down a public road."

Morrison compared the technology to toll bridge cameras that capture images of license plates for billing. While both systems take photos of vehicles, toll system software automatically crops images to display only the license plate, according to Summer Derrey, spokesperson for the Washington State Department of Transportation's North Central Region.

Senate Bill 6002 excludes toll cameras, allowing revenue to continue to be collected to fund, preserve and maintain transportation projects, Derrey said.

"Existing state law is very clear that tolling photographs are to be used exclusively for toll enforcement. Our contracts with vendors provide language on the restriction of sharing customer information," Derrey wrote. "WSDOT is not a law enforcement agency using the images for criminal investigation or any other law enforcement uses."

Senate Bill 6002 could lead to additional statewide regulations for ALPR programs, as Morrison anticipates ALPR cameras will be a "major conversation" during the next legislative session.

"I'm not convinced that we keep this technology yet. I don't think we've had it up long enough... but yeah, I'd say this is great technology. When I've seen it running, yeah, I think we got some positive results back," Morrison said. "I'd like to see it more in action and I have to say one of the biggest deterrents I have with it is the company itself. I don't like doing business with them."

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